

2 carbons

CONSULTANT'S REPORT

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Edgewood: Last year I had recommended a "study first ~~and~~ action second" plan for this school system, with the idea that the staff should have a thorough understanding of the people of the community before trying to adapt their methods and materials to those people. Edgewood has gone ahead with that idea, and we discussed how the initial study period should be worked out and how some action programs may begin to be dovetailed into the study program. It was agreed that the staff of the schools would meet in "institutes" throughout the first year to learn about "Mexicans" in general, and about the "Mexicans" of Edgewood in particular. It is hoped that activities will be organized which will bring about increasing participation of the school patrons, first by the business men and leaders, then by more and more of the rank-and-file.

Pasadena: This system had in mind tentatively that it would take on the "Latin American problem." Discussion developed that it would be best to follow an approach that would not single out a population group for special treatment -- that the stress be placed upon the service to be rendered and that the "Latin Americans" come into the program as simply a sector of the population to be served. Again, emphasis was placed upon the importance of studying the "Mexican problem" thoroughly before special approaches or contacts ~~###~~ are undertaken. This study should include the history of Spanish-speaking people in the U. S., the socio-economic problems that they have faced and are now facing (politics, "wetbacks," health, migration, etc.), as well as particular educational problems of the Pasadena community.

Harlingen: The study approach was recommended here, too. It was also advised that one of the biggest handicaps of the "Latin American" is his isolation . This calls for special emphasis on ways and means of getting him to participate in community programs. Stress was placed on the especial need of the "lower" classes in this matter of participation -- and that it is not enough to get the leaders and the "upper classes" to join in on community and school programs. It was carefully pointed out that the school staff should be thoroughly informed as to the status of the "Latin American" and how that status is affected by the "wetback," by political conditions, by wage scales, etc. Harlingen's educational problems will always be determined largely by some of these factors, since some 60% of its population is of Mexican descent and since that population group is critically affected by the competition of cheap labor from Mexico, by political bossism, etc.